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Examining the influence of Islamic work ethics, organizational politics, and supervisor-initiated workplace incivility on employee deviant behaviors

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ABSTRACT

This study investigates the connection between following Islamic work ethics (IWE) and workplace deviance, and explores the role of perceived organizational politics as a mediator and the impact of incivility initiated by supervisors as a second-stage moderator. Data were collected via a two-wave survey of 205 professionals in various industries. Results show that those who adhere to IWE exhibit a negative link to workplace deviance, as they have less involvement in organizational politics. The study also finds that incivility initiated by supervisors intensifies the positive relationship between perceived organizational politics and workplace deviance. Interestingly, the study shows that the effect of IWE in reducing workplace deviance through organizational politics is stronger when incivility is high. The findings offer valuable insights for organizations on the positive impact of adhering to IWE on reducing perceived organizational politics and workplace deviance.

KEYWORDS

Islamic work ethics; perceived organizational politics; workplace incivility; workplace deviance

INTRODUCTION

Islamic Work Ethics (IWE) refers to the moral principles and values that are derived from the Islamic faith and guide individuals in their professional conduct (Ali, 1988; Husin & Kernain, 2020). These principles include honesty, integrity, responsibility, accountability, fairness, and respect for others, in conjunction with a strong emphasis on hard work, dedication, and punctuality, as well as the importance of fulfilling one's obligations and responsibilities to others (Ahmad & Owoyemi, 2012). IWE also encourages individuals to strive for excellence and to be of service to society, while avoiding actions that may be harmful or exploitative (Javed et al., 2019). Additionally, IWE stresses the importance of being guided by a sense of accountability to God and to one's community, along with the belief that one's actions will be judged and rewarded according to their moral and ethical content (Akhmadi et al., 2023).

Business ethics literature has traditionally focused on identifying the causes of employees' workplace deviance, but there is a lack of research on how adherence to religious beliefs – such as IWE – can help reduce deviant behavior in the workplace (Javed et al., 2018; Zia et al., 2022). Employees who adhere to Islamic Work Ethics are less likely to engage in deviant behaviors in the workplace because they are guided by a set of moral principles that discourage such behaviors. For example, if employees are committed to honesty, they may be less likely to engage in deceitful or fraudulent behavior in order to gain an advantage over their colleagues. Similarly, if employees are committed to fairness, they may be less likely to engage in

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discriminatory behavior or take credit for the work of others. Several studies have found that IWE can lead to positive behavior (Akhmadi et al., 2023; De Clercq et al., 2019; Suryani et al., 2021; Zia et al., 2022) and discourage negative deviance in the workplace (Ahmad & Owoyemi, 2012; Ali, 1992; Javed et al., 2019; Yousef, 2001). We argue that employees with IWE will be less likely to engage in workplace deviance, as they believe that their actions are being watched by Allah and good deeds will be rewarded (Javed et al., 2017; Rawwas et al., 2018).

As we reflect deeper on the relationship between IWE and deviant behavior in light of existing literature, we witness little evidence showing how and when employees' religious beliefs help them in reducing their deviant behavior, which can violate organizational norms and negatively affect productivity (Bennett & Robinson, 2003). Therefore, Yousef (2001) and Zia et al. (2022) recommend that further investigation is necessary to understand the effect of IWE on workplace outcomes. Previous research has emphasized the importance of studying politics due to its prevalence and negative consequences in organizations (Abbas et al., 2014; Naseer et al., 2016; Vigoda & Cohen, 2002). Following Rawwas et al. (2018), we propose that IWE can help reduce politics in the workplace, thereby reducing deviant behaviors. Specifically, we introduce organizational politics as a mediator in the IWE-deviant behavior relationship.

Organizational politics involves engaging in unauthorized, uncivilized, distracting, and illegal behaviors to gain power, resources, and advantages for personal gain (Ferris et al., 1989). It represents an employee's personal evaluation of political self-serving acts of other employees (Ferris & Kacmar, 1992; Ferris et al., 1989). Research has demonstrated that employees who perceive high levels of politics in their workplace are more likely to engage in deviant acts, such as negligent behavior (Meisler & Vigoda-Gadot, 2014; Miller et al., 2008; Vigoda, 2000, 2001). Organizational politics is often associated with a self-serving and negative work environment, leading employees to engage in counterproductive and deviant behaviors (Crawford et al., 2019; Zettler & Hilbig, 2010). In contrast, IWE promotes positive behaviors such as hard work, dedication, and timely completion of tasks, while at the same time discouraging negative and deviant behaviors (Ali, 1988, 1992; Ali & Al-Owaihian, 2008; Düşmezkalender, Secilmis, and Yilmaz, 2021). Research has also shown that employees who adhere to IWE principles are less likely to engage in negligent behavior (Murtaza et al., 2016; Rawwas et al., 2018). Therefore, we argue that employees who follow IWE will be less likely to engage in deviant behavior in a workplace, due to their tendency to avoid involvement in politics to gain power and resources.

In sum, we propose that IWE can reduce the prevalence of organizational politics in the workplace, which in turn reduces deviant behaviors. We go one step further to suggest that the negative effect of IWE on deviant behaviors through organizational politics depends on how supervisors treat their subordinates. Previous studies have shown that employees may react differently to supervisors' abusive behavior, depending on the context (Tepper, 2007; Zhang & Liao, 2015). Employees with a strong sense of IWE tend to act positively and ethically even when facing workplace stressors (Khan et al., 2015; Murtaza et al., 2016). Research shows that supervisor-initiated incivility in the workplace has negative consequences for both the organization and society (Porath & Pearson, 2013). Victims of incivility can develop negative attitudes toward their job and organization, resulting in decreased performance and financial loss (Jawahar & Schreurs, 2018; Schilpzand et al., 2016). While previous studies have focused on the direct effects of workplace incivility (Jawahar & Schreurs, 2018; Schilpzand et al., 2016), it is important to also investigate how incivility acts as a boundary condition on the relationship between organizational politics and workplace deviance. We argue that incivility may exacerbate the positive impact of organizational politics on workplace deviance.

We thus ask the following research questions: *How do employees' IWE impact their workplace deviant behavior through organizational politics?* And, *does supervisor-initiated incivility moderate the indirect relationship between IWE and workplace deviant behavior via organizational politics?* To address our research questions, we apply the conservation of resources (COR) theory (Hobfoll, 2001) to understand how religious resources – such as IWE – can decrease deviant behavior in the workplace. We propose that employees with strong religious resources will be less likely to engage in

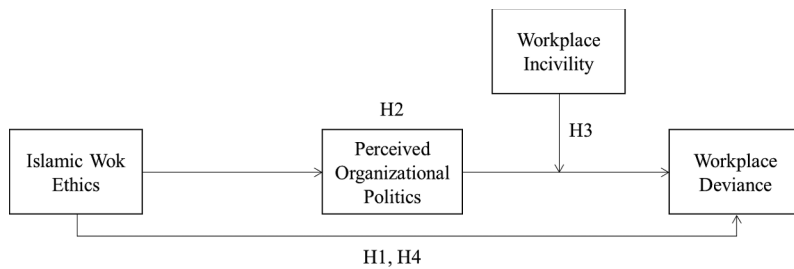


Figure 1. Conceptual model.

deviant behavior when faced with workplace stressor of organizational politics and that religious resources can also act as a buffer against the negative effects of both organizational politics and workplace incivility on deviant behavior, as illustrated in Figure 1.

We contribute to the business ethics research by exploring how and when employees' IWE diminishes workplace deviant behavior. We propose the concept of organizational politics as a link between IWE and workplace deviant behavior and use supervisor-initiated workplace incivility as a factor that moderates this relationship. Our study also offers insights into the significance of IWE in reducing deviance, and expands on previous research in the field. Additionally, we conduct the study in a culturally relevant context of a developing Asian country, where high power distance and uncertainty avoidance may contribute to higher levels of corruption and unethical behavior (Hofstede, 1983, 1991).

THEORY AND HYPOTHESES

IWE and workplace deviance

"Ethics" refers to guiding principles that distinguish right from wrong. Religion is often cited as a key determinant of moral values, with most religions disapproving of unethical behavior (Emerson & McKinney, 2010; Gensler, 2016). In recent decades, research has focused on religious work ethics, and particularly on IWE, due to Islam's large following in North Africa, the Middle East, and Asia (Ali, 1988; Javaid et al., 2022; Kim et al., 2009; Weber, 1992). IWE is derived from the Qur'an and the teachings and practices of Prophet Muhammad, and is considered valid for all Muslims. Intention is the most important criterion in evaluating an act's ethicality in Islam, and actions with malicious intent are considered unlawful (Ali & Al-Owaidan, 2008). The Qur'an states that individuals will be judged based on their deeds. In daily life, Muslims are expected to be cooperative and helpful, and this applies in organizational settings as well, where Islamic principles stress the importance of good interpersonal relationships for creating a productive and helpful environment (Bouma et al., 2003).

Deviant behaviors in the workplace have significant financial consequences for organizations, costing millions – or even billions – of dollars (Christian & Ellis, 2014; Dunlop & Lee, 2004). Research suggests that various personal, organizational, work-related, and contextual factors can contribute to deviant behaviors. For example, work-related factors include job characteristics such as policy-related decisions, as well as issues with supervision such as lack of support or poor communication, and issues with peers such as lack of support or problems with team building. Research has also shown that high levels of IWE can reduce workplace deviance, even in cases where supervisors are abusive (Javed et al., 2019).

We expect a negative relationship between IWE and workplace deviance and interpret it through the lens of the COR theory (Hobfoll, 2001). According to this theory, individuals possess limited resources such as time, money, energy, and social support, and experience stress when these resources are threatened or depleted. Adherence to IWE involves embracing a set of moral principles that

discourage deviant behaviors like dishonesty, unfairness, and disrespect. Thus, by upholding these principles, individuals strive to conserve their valuable resources, including their time, energy, reputation, social support network, personal integrity, and financial well-being (Husin & Kernain, 2020; Javaid et al., 2022).

Specifically, IWE highlights the virtue of dedication to work, emphasizing the importance of actively engaging in tasks. This dedication helps individuals to invest their resources – such as time and energy – into meaningful work, thus reducing their likelihood of engaging in deviant behaviors such as laziness or daydreaming. IWE emphasizes justice and generosity in the workplace as necessary conditions for societal welfare. By promoting fair and equitable treatment, individuals uphold a positive work environment, reducing the occurrence of deviant behaviors like making fun of someone or engaging in racial remarks. In a similar vein, IWE emphasizes carrying out work to the best of one's ability, encouraging individuals to invest their resources into productive efforts. This commitment to excellence reduces the likelihood of engaging in deviant behaviors such as intentionally working slower or putting little effort into work (Husin & Kernain, 2020).

Furthermore, IWE emphasizes the importance of human relations in organizations, promoting positive social interactions. This focus on fostering healthy relationships reduces the likelihood of engaging in harmful behaviors, such as publicly embarrassing someone or acting rudely toward colleagues. Moreover, IWE underscores the value of work being derived from accompanying intentions rather than solely focusing on results. By aligning one's intentions with ethical principles, individuals are able to prioritize the conservation of resources such as integrity and reputation, which discourages deviant behaviors such as falsifying receipts or discussing confidential information. In sum, IWE makes employees believe that their good actions will protect and grow their resources, while their bad actions will make them lose their precious and limited resources that ultimately prevent them from engaging in deviant behaviors in the workplace.

Empirical evidence shows that IWE is negatively associated with counterproductive behaviors such as workplace deviance, and positively associated with various job-related outcomes. For example, some recent studies have shown that IWE reduces workplace deviance behavior (e.g., Düşmezkalender et al., 2021; Javed et al., 2019; Zia et al., 2022). Other research has also found that IWE positively influences organizational commitment (Husin & Kernain, 2020; Yousef, 2001), organizational citizenship behavior and knowledge-sharing behavior (Husin & Kernain, 2020; Javaid et al., 2022; Murtaza et al., 2016), adaptive performance and innovative work behavior (Javed et al., 2017), and job satisfaction and turnover intention (Rokhman, 2010). Based on the theoretical logical backed by the COR theory and empirical evidence, we thus propose that:

Hypothesis 1: *IWE is negatively related to workplace deviance.*

The mediating role of organizational politics

The term “politics” in organizations is often used to refer to the use of power and influence to achieve personal goals at the expense of others or the organization as a whole. This view is supported by mainstream literature, which defines organizational politics as actions taken by individuals to further their own interests without regard for the well-being of others or the organization (Ferris et al., 1989; Kacmar & Baron, 1999). Adding to previous understanding of organizational politics, Cropanzano and Li (2006) emphasize that organizational politics is, in fact, one's subjective appraisal of work environment, and therefore, perceived environment of politics in the workplace impacts how employees think, feel, and act in organizations.

Building on our previous hypothesis of the negative relationship between IWE and workplace deviance rooted in the COR theory, we further extend our view by introducing perceived organizational politics as a mechanism that explains why IWE might be associated negatively

with workplace deviance. Perceived organizational politics highlight behaviors associated with self-interest, power struggles, and manipulation within the organization. For instance, factors such as tearing others down, influential groups, and the importance of agreement with powerful others reflect an environment where personal gain is prioritized over collective well-being. These behaviors are incongruent with the ethical principles and values advocated for by IWE.

Drawing from the COR theory, we can infer that individuals who prioritize IWE conserve their resources by avoiding engagement in organizational politics. By adhering to principles such as dedication to work, justice, and generosity, individuals are less likely to involve themselves in behaviors that promote personal gain at the expense of others. This adherence allows them to preserve valuable resources, including their reputation, social support, and integrity, which are crucial for personal and professional growth. Moreover, individuals who embody the ethical principles of IWE are less likely to perceive organizational politics within their work environment. This perception arises due to the misalignment between the values of IWE and the self-serving behaviors associated with organizational politics. Individuals who prioritize IWE are more inclined to foster positive relationships, promote fairness and honesty, and contribute to the well-being of their organization, thus diminishing the prevalence of perceived organizational politics.

On the other hand, the perception of political behaviors within the organization can create a resource-depleting environment, leading to an increase in workplace deviant behaviors. When employees perceive high levels of organizational politics, this indicates the presence of behaviors such as tearing others down, the existence of influential groups, and a culture where speaking out frankly is discouraged. These political behaviors create a sense of competition, power struggles, and a lack of fairness within the organization. As a result, employees may perceive their resources, such as opportunities for growth, recognition, and fair treatment, to be at risk.

The perception of organizational politics can trigger negative emotional responses, such as feelings of injustice, mistrust, and frustration, among employees. These emotional reactions, coupled with the perception of resource depletion, can lead individuals to engage in deviant behaviors as a way to regain a sense of control or seek personal gains within the organization. Deviant behaviors – such as engaging in personal matters during work hours, taking property without permission, or spreading rumors – are means through which individuals attempt to address their perceived resource deficits or retaliate against perceived injustices. Furthermore, the perception that pay and promotion decisions are influenced by political factors rather than being based on objective policies can create a sense of unfairness and injustice among employees. This perception undermines the employees' trust in the organization and its systems, leading to increased workplace deviance as a way to express dissatisfaction or seek personal advantages. This can also create a negative impact on employees' overall productivity and the organization's performance (Vigoda, 2000).

Based on the above explanation, we thus propose that organizational politics can act as a mediator in the relationship between Islamic work ethics and workplace deviant behavior. We expect that a higher level of IWE will be associated with a lower level of organizational politics which will ultimately be associated with lower level of workplace deviance.

At the empirical level, organizational politics can negatively impact employee performance by creating feelings of inequity and leading to negative attitudes and behaviors. Studies have shown that organizational politics can lead to reduced job satisfaction (Ferris & Kacmar, 1992), dissatisfaction with supervisors, and reduced organizational commitment (Maslyn & Fedor, 1998). It has also been linked to decreased in-role and extra-role performance (Eran Vigoda-Gadot, 2007). Additionally, organizational politics has been found to be positively related to withholding information, absenteeism (Vigoda-Gadot et al., 2003), job anxiety (Ferris et al., 1996), stress and job burnout (Vigoda-Gadot & Talmud, 2010), counterproductive work behavior (Bashir et al., 2019; Rosen, 2006), and turnover intentions (Maslyn & Fedor, 1998). In a recent study of university teachers, Atta and Khan (2016) found a negative relationship between organizational politics and productive work behaviors. The idea is that

employees tend to behave negatively when they perceive organizational politics, whereas fair exchange relationships may reduce the level of organizational politics (Vigoda-Gadot, 2007). Thus, we hypothesize that:

Hypothesis 2: *Organizational politics mediates the negative relationship between IWE and workplace deviance.*

The moderating role of supervisor-initiated workplace incivility

Workplace incivility, defined as low-intensity deviant behavior with ambiguous intent to harm (Andersson & Pearson, 1999), has become a prevalent phenomenon in the workplace (Porath & Pearson, 2013) and gained attention from researchers in recent years (Schilpzand et al., 2016). This can include derogatory remarks, not listening to others, and discourteous and rude behavior (Porath & Pearson, 2013), and can be inflicted by coworkers, leaders/supervisors, or even customers. It can cause significant financial consequences for organizations, such as decreased work effort and negative interactions with customers (Porath & Pearson, 2013). Targets of workplace incivility also experience high levels of distress and low motivation, which can increase their intentions to quit (Bowling & Beehr, 2006). This study focuses on incivility initiated by supervisors, as it has significant consequences for organizations from a performance perspective (Jawahar & Schreurs, 2018) as well as for individuals in terms of health and quality of life (Hogan & Kaiser, 2005).

Another reason for focusing on supervisor-initiated workplace incivility is that it can be more harmful than incivility from coworkers or customers because supervisors directly evaluate employees for rewards and promotions. Supervisor-initiated incivility is considered emotional abuse, which can decrease employee morale (Hershcovis & Barling, 2010). Therefore, supervisor incivility can bring about severe negative behavioral outcomes. A review of 15 years of research on workplace incivility found a negative association between incivility and various job-related outcomes, including employee attitudes and behaviors (Schilpzand et al., 2016). Studies have shown that incivility lowers in-role and extra-role performance and work engagement (Chen & Li, 2013; Taylor et al., 2012). A recent study by Jawahar and Schreurs (2018) found that even when employees have more trust in their supervisors, supervisor-initiated incivility still lowers in-role and extra-role performance.

Supervisor-initiated workplace incivility can create a risky situation from an organizational perspective and put performance goals at risk when employees perceive organizational politics. The combination of high organizational politics and supervisor-initiated incivility can create a perception of inequity and unfairness among employees. When individuals perceive that resources, rewards, and opportunities are distributed based on political considerations or biased treatment, they may feel a diminished sense of justice that can lead to the depletion of emotional and psychological resources and increase the likelihood of negative outcomes, even if the employee trusts the supervisor (Jawahar & Schreurs, 2018; Naseer et al., 2016). In such circumstances, employees might justify engaging in workplace deviance as a method for regaining a sense of control, retaliating, or restoring their perceived equity. This deviant behavior serves as a counterproductive response to the perceived injustice within the organization. Thus, we propose that:

Hypothesis 3: *Supervisor-initiated workplace incivility moderates the positive relationship between organizational politics and workplace deviance such that a higher level of workplace incivility will strengthen this relationship, and vice versa.*

Conditional indirect relation of IWE and workplace deviance

The COR theory provides a valuable framework to justify the proposed hypothesis that the indirect negative effect of Islamic Work Ethics on workplace deviant behavior – mediated by organizational politics – is moderated by supervisor-initiated workplace incivility. According to the COR theory, individuals strive to acquire and maintain resources that are crucial for their well-being and functioning within organizations. IWE, which encompasses values such as fairness, justice, and integrity, can be seen as valuable resources that individuals draw upon to guide their behavior. In the presence of organizational politics, employees with strong IWE may rely on these values as resources for navigating the uncertain and politically charged environment. However, when supervisors engage in workplace incivility, it depletes the emotional and psychological resources of employees, compromising their ability to draw upon their IWE effectively. This resource depletion can intensify the negative impact of organizational politics, weakening the indirect effect of IWE on reducing workplace deviant behavior. Thus, supervisor-initiated workplace incivility acts as a moderator in the relationship between IWE, organizational politics, and workplace deviance, influencing the strength of the indirect effect. We expect that employees who follow IWE principles would be resilient to supervisor-initiated incivility and less likely to engage in workplace deviance.

Hypothesis 4: *The indirect negative effect of IWE on workplace deviant behavior via organizational politics is moderated by the supervisor-initiated workplace incivility.*

METHOD

Sample and procedures

This study was approved by the Research Ethics Committee of the University of the first author and was conducted in accordance with ethical guidelines and standards. All participants provided written informed consent, and measures were taken to protect their privacy and confidentiality.

A two-wave survey through network sampling was conducted among 205 professionals from construction and industrial organizations located in Lahore, Attock, and Karachi. During the first wave, respondents were evaluated on their Islamic work ethics, experiences with workplace incivility, and demographic characteristics. After a three-week interval, the same respondents who had participated in the first wave were contacted to collect the response on their perceptions of organizational politics and workplace deviance. Prior to consenting to participate, participants were given an invitation letter explaining the goals of the study and a statement ensuring the confidentiality of their involvement. A unique identifier was assigned to each questionnaire in the first wave for the purpose of matching, as the respondents remained the same in both waves.

The sample for this study – consisting of 205 professionals from construction and industrial organizations in Lahore, Attock, and Karachi – met the sample size requirements set by researchers for survey research in behavioral sciences (see more, Memon & Ghani, 2020; Roscoe, 1975; Sekaran & Bougie, 2016). The majority of participants were aged between 18 and 45 (90.8%). The sample was predominantly male (91.2%), with 77.6% having graduation level qualifications. The largest proportion of participants was employed in engineering (37.1%), followed by the education department (36.6%) and technology firms (26.3%). The participants had experience ranging from 1–5 years (36.6%) to 16–20 years (7.3%). The sample was comprised of a mix of project types, including construction (37.1%), training and development (58.5%), and machinery installation (4.4%). The majority of the projects had a size of more than 50 million (60.0%). The project

duration ranged from less than 3 months (36.6%) to more than 2 years (37.1%). The project team size varied, with the largest proportion having 5–10 members (42.9%) and 37.1% having more than 30 members.

Measures

Workplace Deviance

A 19-item scale was adopted from Bennett and Robinson (2000) to assess workplace deviance. The respondents rated items using a 7-point Likert-type scale ranging from 1 (*never*) to 7 (*daily*). A sample item included “Intentionally worked slower than you could have worked.” $\alpha = 0.87$

Islamic Work Ethics

A 17-item (short version) scale was adopted from Ali (1992) to assess Islamic work ethics. The respondents rated items using a 5-point Likert scale which ranged from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree*). Sample items included “Laziness is a vice” and “Dedication to work is a virtue.” $\alpha = 0.84$

Perceived Organizational Politics

We adopted a 15-item scale from Kacmar and Carlson (1997) to assess perceived organizational politics. The respondents rated each item using a 5-point Likert scale which ranged from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree*). A sample item included “People in this organization attempt to build themselves up by tearing others down.” $\alpha = 0.82$

Workplace Incivility

We assessed workplace incivility initiated by supervisor using a 7-item scale adopted from Bennett and Robinson (2000). The respondents rated each item using a 5-point Likert scale which ranged from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree*). A sample item included “Put you down or was condescending to you.” $\alpha = 0.87$

The complete questionnaire is presented in [Appendix 1](#).

RESULTS

Results of descriptive statistics, correlations, and reliability

Table 1 presents descriptive statistics, zero-order correlations, and reliability estimates for our four main study variables. Additionally, we collected data regarding various personal and project-related variables. We excluded those variables from our analyses whose correlations with our main variables were not significant, such as age, gender, education, organization type, and project type. The variables having significant correlation with our main variables included experience, project size, project duration, and project team size. We used them as control variables in later analyses.

Table 1. Descriptive statistics, zero-order correlations, and reliability.

Variable	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1. Islamic Work Ethics (T1)	4.13	.47	(.84)						
2. Organizational Politics (T2)	3.46	.69	-.20**	(.82)					
3. Workplace Incivility (T1)	3.43	.92	.06	.14	(.87)				
4. Workplace Deviance (T2)	4.64	1.06	-.43***	.49***	.32***	(.91)			
5. Experience	1.98	.93	.08	-.04	-.01	-.15*			
6. Project Size	2.60	.49	-.13	.10	-.05	.25***	-.08		
7. Project Duration	3.28	2.02	-.18*	.21**	.01	.32***	-.06	.83***	
8. Project Team Size	2.46	1.36	-.11	.16*	.01	.23**	-.03	.82***	.91***

Note. $N = 205$. Values along the diagonal are Alpha reliabilities.

* $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.

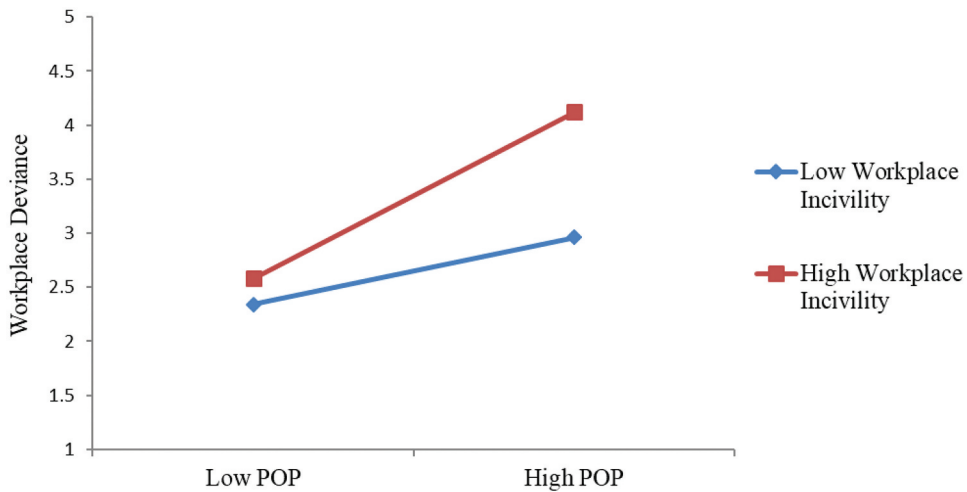


Figure 2. Combined effect of POP and workplace incivility on workplace deviance.

Test of common method bias

We employed Herman's single factor method to evaluate the potential impact of common method bias on our study results. According to this method, all items were loaded onto a single factor without undergoing rotation. The single factor analysis revealed that only 16.3% of the variance was accounted for, which is significantly lower than the widely accepted cutoff threshold of 50% variance. This low variance suggests that the common method bias did not play a significant role in the outcome of our study and that our findings can be considered trustworthy. It is worth mentioning that common method bias refers to the systematic error that occurs when using a single method to measure multiple constructs. This bias can affect the validity of the results, and can result in an overestimation of the relationship between the constructs. In order to mitigate this bias, multiple methods or sources of data should be used in the study design. In our case, however, the use of a single factor method proved sufficient in ensuring the validity of our results.

Results of hypotheses testing

We tested Hypotheses 1 and 2 by using model 4 of the Process procedure developed by Hayes (2013) in SPSS. The results revealed that the direct effect of IWE on workplace deviance was statistically significant ($\beta = -.83, p < .001$), providing support for Hypothesis 1.

The bias-corrected bootstrap method was employed for mediation, and generated 5,000 bootstrap samples with a 95% level of confidence for the confidence intervals. The results of this analysis revealed that the mediation effect of organizational politics was statistically significant ($\beta = -.17, 95\% \text{ CI } [-.296, -.070]$), as the confidence interval did not include zero. Therefore, Hypothesis 2 was supported by the data. We tested both H1 and H2 after controlling experience, project size, project duration, and team size due to significant correlation with workplace deviance, and it is likely that these variables could influence the results. However, we received similar results (IWE $\rightarrow$ workplace deviance $\beta = -.74$ and IWE $\rightarrow$ POP $\rightarrow$ workplace deviance $\beta = -.13, 95\% \text{ CI } [-.296, -.070]$).

To test Hypothesis 3, we employed model 14 of the Process procedure (Hayes, 2013) to analyze the moderated mediation model. The results revealed a statistically significant interactive effect of organizational politics and workplace incivility on workplace deviance ($\beta = .23, p < .01$). To further understand this interaction effect, we conducted a slope test and visualized the results in Figure 2. The results showed that when individuals perceive high levels of organizational politics, they are more

likely to engage in deviant behavior when they also experience high levels of workplace incivility. These findings provide evidence to support Hypothesis 3.

Finally, we conducted a comprehensive analysis of our moderated mediation model to examine the effect of IWE on workplace deviance through organizational politics, taking into account the moderating effect of workplace incivility. Results revealed that the negative effect of IWE on workplace deviance via organizational politics was statistically significant (unstandardized effect size = -0.22 , 95% CI $[-0.374, -0.071]$) only when workplace incivility was high, as compared to when it was low (unstandardized effect size = -0.10 , 95% CI $[-0.216, .002]$). Additionally, the index of moderated mediation was found to be statistically significant (unstandardized effect size = -0.07 , 95% CI $[-0.159, -0.001]$). This supports the notion that IWE has a stronger effect on reducing workplace deviance through organizational politics when incivility is high.

DISCUSSION

This study contributes to the field of business ethics research by demonstrating how employees' adherence to IWE can help mitigate the negative effects of organizational politics and workplace incivility on workplace deviance. As hypothesized by drawing from the COR theory (Hobfoll, 2001), we found a negative relationship between IWE and both organizational politics and workplace deviance. Our results indicated that organizational politics mediated this negative relationship. Furthermore, we discovered that supervisor-initiated workplace incivility within a political environment exacerbated the relationship between organizational politics and workplace deviance. However, employees who followed IWE principles were found to be resilient to supervisor-initiated incivility, and were less likely to engage in workplace deviance.

Theoretical implications

This study makes theoretical contributions to the existing literature on IWE, workplace deviance, and organizational politics. Our findings demonstrate a consistent negative relationship between employees' adherence to IWE and their perceptions of politics and workplace deviance that are in alignment with preceding research, which asserts that IWE functions as a psychological resource, inspiring employees to demonstrate prosocial behaviors and simultaneously deterring them from engaging in counterproductive actions like office politics and workplace deviance. (Gotsis & Kortezi, 2010; Islam et al., 2021; Javed et al., 2019).. By corroborating these previous findings, our study strengthens the understanding of the role of IWE as a valuable resource for shaping employee behavior in the organizational context – particularly in Pakistan, where the majority of the population ascribes to the Islamic faith.

Secondly, our study sought to investigate the association between IWE and workplace deviance while at the same time exploring the mediating role of organizational politics in this relationship. Our results provide support for the mediating role of organizational politics in the link between IWE and workplace deviance. This finding is consistent with prior research conducted by Cropanzano and Li (2006) and Ferris et al. (1996), which suggests that employees who adhere to IWE are less likely to engage in organizational politics, consequently leading to a reduction in workplace deviance. By replicating and extending these previous findings, our study reinforces the understanding that IWE has a significant impact on organizational politics, which in turn affects the occurrence of workplace deviance.

Furthermore, the perception of the work environment as political, where employees believe they must engage in competition for limited resources such as power, relationships, or key positions (Ferris et al., 1989; Kacmar & Ferris, 1991), has been linked to an increase in workplace deviance (O'Neill et al., 2013). However, individuals who adhere to IWE hold the belief that their actions are constantly observed by Allah, and they anticipate judgment and rewards based on their deeds (Javed et al., 2017). This religious conviction discourages them from engaging in deviant behaviors. Furthermore, the positive energy derived from IWE fosters a strong focus on performing their jobs to the best of their

abilities and promotes the sharing of benefits with others, thereby reducing the need for engaging in political behaviors. By highlighting the influence of IWE in deterring workplace deviance in the context of organizational politics, our study contributes to a deeper understanding of the factors that shape employee behavior and inform interventions aimed at promoting ethical conduct within organizations.

Thirdly, we aimed to investigate the moderating role of workplace incivility in the relationship between organizational politics and workplace deviance. Our findings provide empirical support for the notion that workplace incivility, as a significant workplace stressor, amplifies the positive impact of organizational politics on workplace deviance, which is consistent with the studies by Jawahar and Schreurs (2018) and Naseer et al. (2016). This suggests that the presence of workplace incivility in the organizational environment increases the likelihood of employees engaging in deviant behaviors, as it impairs their ability to effectively carry out their job responsibilities, as highlighted by Estes and Wang (2008) and Sliter et al. (2012). The combination of organizational politics and workplace incivility creates a toxic work environment that heightens the pressure on employees and compels them to resort to deviant behaviors as a coping mechanism, as suggested by Wu, Zhang, Chiu, Kwan, and He (2014). These findings underscore the significance of fostering a positive workplace culture that minimizes workplace stressors and promotes positive organizational behavior.

Finally, we additionally examined the moderated mediational model of workplace deviance, contributing to the existing body of research. Our findings align with prior studies that have investigated the moderated mediational effects of personal resources on deviant workplace behaviors, as demonstrated by Cropanzano and Li (2006b) and Ferris et al. (1996). Building upon this literature, our study highlights the significant role of IWE as a personal resource that can attenuate the negative influence of political organizational behavior and workplace incivility on workplace deviance. Notably, our results suggest that employees who uphold IWE principles are more likely to exhibit positive behaviors despite the presence of workplace stressors such as workplace incivility. This indicates that IWE can serve as a protective factor against deviant workplace behaviors (Javed et al., 2017). These findings reinforce the notion that individuals with a strong personal resource base are better equipped to navigate workplace stressors and sustain positive behaviors (Cropanzano & Li, 2006b).

Practical implications

Our study provides valuable practical implications for organizations and leaders – particularly those operating in Muslim countries like Pakistan or with a significant Muslim employee population. Firstly, organizations must prioritize the promotion of strong IWE principles in the workplace. IWE has been found to positively influence employees' ethical behaviors (Rawwas et al., 2018), and can play a crucial role in reducing counterproductive work behaviors such as organizational politics, workplace incivility, and workplace deviance (Chernyak-Hai & Tzine, 2014). Leaders should therefore encourage employees to follow these principles and promote them within the organizational culture.

To create a positive and ethical work environment, organizations can provide training to their leaders and employees to promote ethical behaviors and minimize workplace deviance. This can be achieved by reinforcing the importance of IWE in the workplace (Ali & Al-Kazemi, 2007) and promoting ethical values from top to bottom in the organizational culture (Appelbaum et al., 2005). Such training can help employees understand and adhere to acceptable workplace norms, thereby reducing workplace incivility and deviant behaviors.

Our findings suggest that employees with strong IWE beliefs are more resilient to workplace stressors and less likely to engage in deviant behaviors in the face of political organizational behavior and workplace incivility (Javed et al., 2017). To mitigate the impact of workplace stressors on employees' deviant behaviors, organizations must provide training to employees and leaders to effectively manage workplace conflict and stress (De Clercq et al., 2019; Pearson & Porath, 2005). Providing structural empowerment, such as access to information, support, resources, and growth

opportunities, can also help to diminish the harmful effects of perceived organizational politics and workplace incivility (Spence Laschinger et al., 2009).

Finally, organizations must take proactive measures to minimize the negative effects of workplace incivility and perceived organizational politics on workplace deviance. To address workplace incivility and perceived organizational politics, organizations must create a culture of mutual respect and provide training for employees at all levels to manage conflict and stress (De Clercq et al., 2019; Pearson & Porath, 2005). By promoting IWE principles within the organization, leaders can foster a culture of ethical behavior and mitigate counterproductive work behaviors, thus leading to improved organizational effectiveness (Ali & Al-Kazemi, 2007).

STRENGTHS, LIMITATIONS, AND SUGGESTIONS FOR FUTURE RESEARCH

A limitation of this study is the reliance on self-reports, which raises concerns regarding common source bias (Podsakoff et al., 2003). To minimize such concerns, we measured IWE and supervisor-initiated workplace incivility at time 1, and organizational politics and workplace deviance at time 2. This design helps to reduce the potential impact of common source bias on our results. However, it is important to note that the measures of IWE, workplace incivility, organizational politics, and workplace deviance are subjective in nature, and best measured through self-report methods.

To further deepen our understanding of the relationship between IWE and workplace deviance, future studies could employ longitudinal or diary research designs. This will provide a more in-depth examination of the underlying mechanisms of IWE and workplace deviance. In addition, our results show partial mediation, implying that there may be other processes at play in explaining the relationship between IWE and workplace deviance. Future research could investigate additional intervening variables, such as job dissatisfaction, job-related anxiety, or other work-related indicators, in order to gain a more comprehensive understanding of this relationship.

From a practical perspective, it is crucial for future research to examine the coping mechanisms for mitigating the effects of organizational politics on employees' workplace deviance. Given the positive impact of organizational politics and workplace incivility on workplace deviance, it is important to understand how employees can cope with these stressors and maintain positive behaviors. This information could provide valuable insights for organizations and leaders who are seeking to create a positive work environment and reduce counterproductive work behaviors.

CONCLUSION

In this study, we investigated how adherence to Islamic Work Ethics can mitigate the negative effects of perceived organizational politics, supervisor-initiated workplace incivility, and deviant behavior in the context of a developing country. Our findings contribute to the existing literature by providing a theoretical understanding of the positive effects of IWE on reducing organizational politics and workplace deviance. We hope that this research will inspire future studies to further explore the underlying and coping mechanisms that are involved in the relationship between IWE and workplace deviance. Given the cultural context of our study, our findings hold particular relevance for Muslim countries and organizations with Muslim employees.

DISCLOSURE STATEMENT

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

The authenticity of data is sole responsibility of the first author and available upon a reasonable request.

AUTHORS' CONTRIBUTIONS

All authors made equal contributions to this work. Dr. Shazia Nauman played a vital role in conceptualizing the idea, data collection, and writing the introduction and discussion sections. Dr. Ameer A. Basit was involved in conceptualizing the idea, analyzing the data, and writing the methods and results sections. Dr. Hassan Imam contributed to the conceptualization of the idea, as well as writing the literature review, limitations, and future research directions. Additionally, all authors collaborated in the manuscript revision process to ensure its quality and coherence.

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Appendix 1

Workplace deviance (Bennett & Robinson, 2000)

- WPD1 Worked on a personal matter instead of work for your employer.
- WPD2 Taken property from work without permission.
- WPD3 Spent too much time fantasizing or daydreaming instead of working.
- WPD4 Made fun of someone at work
- WPD5 Falsified a receipt to get reimbursed for more money than you spend on business expenses.
- WPD6 Said something harmful to someone at work.
- WPD7 Taken an additional or a longer break than is acceptable at your workplace.
- WPD8 Repeated a rumor or gossip about your company.
- WPD9 Made an ethnic, religious, or racial remark or joke at work.
- WPD10 Come in late to work without permission.
- WPD11 Littered your work environment.
- WPD12 Cursed at someone at work.
- WPD13 Called in sick when you were not.
- WPD14 Told someone about the lousy place where you work.
- WPD15 Lost your temper while at work.
- WPD16 Neglected to follow your boss's instructions.
- WPD17 Intentionally worked slower than you could have worked.
- WPD18 Discussed confidential company information with an unauthorized person.
- WPD19 Left work early without permission.
- WPD20 Played a mean prank on someone at work.
- WPD21 Left your work for someone else to finish.
- WPD22 Acted rudely toward someone at work.
- WPD23 Repeated a rumor or gossip about your boss or coworkers.
- WPD24 Made an obscene comment at work.
- WPD25 Used an illegal drug or consumed alcohol on the job.
- WPD26 Put little effort into your work.
- WPD27 Publicly embarrassed someone at work.
- WPD28 Dragged out work in order to get overtime.

Perceived organizational politics (Kacmar & Carlson, 1997)

- POP1 People in this organization attempt to build themselves up by tearing others down.
- POP2 There has always been an influential group in this department that no one ever crosses.
- POP3 Employees are encouraged to speak out frankly even when they are critical of well-established ideas.
- POP4 There is no place for yes-men around here; good ideas are desired even if it means disagreeing with superiors.
- POP5 Agreeing with powerful others is the best alternative in this organization.
- POP6 It is best not to rock the boat in this organization.
- POP7 Sometimes it is easier to remain quiet than to fight the system.
- POP8 Telling others what they want to hear is sometime better than telling the truth.
- POP9 It is safer to think what you are told than to make up your own mind.
- POP10 Since I have worked in this department, I have never seen the pay and promotion policies applied politically.
- POP11 I can't remember when a person received a pay increase or promotion that was inconsistent with the published policies.
- POP12 None of the raises I have received are consistent with the policies on how raises should be determined.
- POP13 The stated pay and promotion policies have nothing to do with how pay raises and promotions are determined.
- POP14 When it comes to pay raise and promotion decisions, policies are irrelevant.
- POP15 Promotions around here are not valued much because how they determined is so political.

Islamic work ethics (Ali, 1992)

- IWE1 Laziness is a vice.
- IWE2 Dedication to work is a virtue.
- IWE3 Good work benefits both one's self and others.
- IWE4 Justice and generosity in the workplace are necessary conditions for society's welfare.

(Continued)

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| IWE5 | Producing more than enough to meet one's personal needs contributes to the prosperity of society as a whole. |
| IWE6 | One should carry work out to the best of one's ability. |
| IWE7 | Work is not an end in itself but a means to foster personal growth and social relations. |
| IWE8 | Life has no meaning without work. |
| IWE9 | More leisure time is good. (R) |
| IWE10 | Human relations in organizations should be emphasized and encouraged. |
| IWE11 | Work enables man to control nature. |
| IWE12 | Creative work is a source of happiness and accomplishment. |
| IWE13 | Any man who works is more likely to get ahead in life. |
| IWE14 | Work gives one the chance to be independent. |
| IWE15 | A successful man is the one who meets deadlines at work. |
| IWE16 | One should constantly work hard to meet responsibilities. |
| IWE17 | The value of work is derived from accompanying intention rather than its results. |

Workplace incivility (Bennett and Robinson (2000))

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| WPI1 | Said something hurtful to someone at work. |
| WPI2 | Made an inappropriate remark at work. |
| WPI3 | Cursed at someone at work. |
| WPI4 | Played a mean prank on someone at work. |
| WPI5 | Acted rudely toward someone at work. |
| WPI6 | Publicly embarrassed someone at work. |
| WPI7 | Made fun of someone at work. |
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